

THIRTEEN

THE VISION FOR THE APPOINTED TIME¹

Son of man, what is this proverb that ye have in the land of Israel, saying, The days are prolonged, and every vision faileth?²

'Where there is no vision the people cast off restraint' (Prov. 29: 18) or, as the Authorised Version has it, with more sense but less philological justification, the 'people perisheth'. Utopias have always cajoled, and eased the burdens of, mankind. The notable point about the Utopias of the Hebrew Scriptures is that the future they depict is in principle open to all. Even when, as so often, the central place in the picture is occupied by the restored Israel, it is an Israel which has been thrice purged and to which 'all flesh' has been added. In 'that day', indeed, it is rather 'all flesh' which includes Israel than Israel which includes 'all flesh'. The typical prophetic message is addressed to all humankind: 'He hath shewed thee, O man, what is good.'

The voice of one that crieth, Prepare ye in the wilderness the way of the Lord, make straight in the desert a high way for our God.

Every valley shall be exalted, and every mountain and hill shall be made low: and the crooked shall be made straight, and the rough places plain.

And the glory of the Lord shall be revealed, and all flesh shall see it together.³

And it shall come to pass afterward, that I will pour out my spirit upon all flesh; and your sons and your

¹Hab. 2: 3.

²Ezek. 12: 22.

³Isa. 40: 3-5.

daughters shall prophesy, your old men shall dream dreams, your young men shall see visions: and also upon the servants and upon the handmaids in those days will I pour out my spirit.¹

There shall be poured upon us a spirit from on high.²

And your eyes shall see and ye shall say, The Lord be magnified beyond the border of Israel.³

Look unto me, and be ye saved, all the ends of the earth: for I am God, and there is none else.⁴

The Lord God which gathereth the outcasts of Israel saith, Yet will I gather others to him, beside his own that are gathered.⁵

The stranger, that is not of thy people Israel, shall come out of a far country for thy name's sake.⁶

For the earth shall be filled with the knowledge of the glory of the Lord, as the waters cover the sea.⁷

And it shall come to pass in the latter days, that the mountain of the Lord's house shall be established in the top of the mountains, and it shall be exalted above the hills; and peoples shall flow unto it. And many nations shall go and say, Come ye, and let us go up to the mountain of the Lord, and to the house of the God of Jacob; and he will teach us of his ways, and we will walk in his paths: for out of Zion shall go forth the law, and the word of the Lord from Jerusalem.

And he shall judge between many peoples, and shall

¹Joel, 2: 28-29.
²Isa. 32: 15 (OA).

³Mal. 1: 5.
⁴Isa. 45: 22.

⁵Isa. 56: 8.
⁶1 Kings 8: 41.

⁷Hab. 2: 14.

reprove strong nations afar off; and they shall beat their swords into plowshares, and their spears into pruning-hooks: nation shall not lift up sword against nation, neither shall they learn war any more. But they shall sit every man under his vine and under his fig tree; and none shall make them afraid: for the mouth of the Lord of hosts hath spoken it.¹

For all the armour of the armed man in the tumult, and the garments rolled in blood, shall even be for burning, for fuel of fire.²

He maketh wars to cease unto the end of the earth;
He breaketh the bow, and cutteth the spear in sunder;
He burneth the chariots in the fire.³

The extortioner is brought to nought, spoiling ceaseth, the oppressors are consumed out of the land.⁴

And he will destroy in this mountain the face of the covering that is cast over all peoples, and the veil that is spread over all nations. He hath swallowed up death for ever; and the Lord God will wipe away tears from off all faces; and the reproach of his people shall he take away from off all the earth: for the Lord hath spoken it.⁵

I will ransom them from the power of the grave; I will redeem them from death: O death, where are thy plagues? O grave, where is thy destruction?⁶

Thy dead shall live; my dead bodies shall arise. Awake and sing, ye that dwell in the dust: for thy dew is as

¹Mic. 4: 1-4 (OA).

²Isa. 9: 5.

³Ps. 46: 9.

⁴Isa. 16: 4.

⁵Isa. 25: 7-8.

⁶Hos. 13: 14.

the dew of herbs, and the earth shall cast forth the dead.¹

And there shall come forth a shoot out of the stock of Jesse, and a branch out of his roots shall bear fruit: and the spirit of the Lord shall rest upon him, the spirit of wisdom and understanding, the spirit of counsel and might, the spirit of knowledge and of the fear of the Lord; and his delight shall be in the fear of the Lord: and he shall not judge after the sight of his eyes, neither reprove after the hearing of his ears: but with righteousness shall he judge the poor, and reprove with equity for the meek of the earth: and he shall smite the earth with the rod of his mouth, and with the breath of his lips shall he slay the wicked. And righteousness shall be the girdle of his loins, and faithfulness the girdle of his reins.

And the wolf shall dwell with the lamb, and the leopard shall lie down with the kid; and the calf and the young lion and the fatling together; and a little child shall lead them. And the cow and the bear shall feed; their young ones shall lie down together: and the lion shall eat straw like the ox. And the sucking child shall play on the hole of the asp, and the weaned child shall put his hand on the basilisk's den.

They shall not hurt nor destroy in all my holy mountain: for the earth shall be full of the knowledge of the Lord, as the waters cover the sea.²

For then will I turn to the peoples a pure language, that they may all call upon the name of the Lord, to serve him with one consent.³

Unto me every knee shall bend and every tongue shall swear.⁴

¹Isa. 26: 19.

²Isa. 11. 1-9.

³Zeph. 3: 9.

⁴Isa. 45: 23.

Behold, the days come, saith the Lord God, that I will send a famine in the land, not a famine of bread, nor a thirst for water, but of hearing the words of the Lord.¹

Ho, every one that thirsteth, come ye to the waters, and he that hath no money; come ye, buy, and eat; yea, come, buy wine and milk without money and without price.

Wherefore do ye spend money for that which is not bread? and your labour for that which satisfieth not? hearken diligently unto me, and eat ye that which is good, and let your soul delight itself in fatness.²

O taste and see that the Lord is good:
Blessed is the man that trusteth in him.³

O thou that hearest prayer,
Unto thee shall all flesh come.⁴

All nations whom thou hast made shall come and worship before thee, O Lord.⁵

For mine house shall be called an house of prayer for all peoples.⁶

Thus saith the Lord of hosts: It shall yet come to pass, that there shall come peoples, and the inhabitants of many cities: and the inhabitants of one city shall go to another, saying, Let us go speedily to intreat the favour of the Lord, and to seek the Lord of hosts: I will go also. Yea, many peoples and strong nations shall come to seek the Lord of hosts in Jerusalem, and to intreat the favour of the Lord.

¹Amos 5: 11.
²Isa. 55: 1-2.

³Ps. 34: 8.
⁴Ps. 65: 2.

⁵Ps. 86: 9.
⁶Isa. 56: 7.

Thus saith the Lord of hosts: In those days it shall come to pass, that ten men shall take hold, out of all the languages of the nations, shall even take hold of the skirt of him that is a Jew, saying, We will go with you, for we have heard that God is with you.¹

Glorious things are spoken of thee,
O city of God. [Selah
I will make mention of Rahab and Babylon as among
them that know me.
Behold Philistia, and Tyre, with Ethiopia;
This one was born there.
Yea, of Zion it shall be said, This one and that one was
born in her;
And the Most High himself shall establish her.
The Lord shall count, when he writeth up the peoples,
This one was born there.² [Selah

And it shall come to pass in that day, that the root of Jesse, which standeth for an ensign of the peoples, unto him shall the nations seek; and his resting place shall be glorious.³

And many nations shall join themselves to the Lord in that day, and shall be my people.⁴

In that day there shall be five cities in the land of Egypt that speak the language of Canaan, and swear to the Lord of hosts; one shall be called The city of destruction.

In that day shall there be an altar to the Lord in the midst of the land of Egypt, and a pillar at the border thereof to the Lord. And it shall be for a sign and for a witness unto the Lord of hosts in the land of

¹Zech. 8: 20-23.

²Ps. 87: 3-6.

³Isa. 11: 10.

⁴Zech. 2: 11.

Egypt: for they shall cry unto the Lord because of the oppressors, and he shall send them a saviour, and a defender, and he shall deliver them. And the Lord shall be known to Egypt, and the Egyptians shall know the Lord in that day; yea, they shall worship with sacrifice and oblation, and shall vow a vow unto the Lord, and shall perform it. And the Lord shall smite Egypt, smiting and healing; and they shall return unto the Lord and he shall be intreated of them, and shall heal them.

In that day shall there be a high way out of Egypt to Assyria, and the Assyrian shall come into Egypt, and the Egyptian into Assyria; and the Egyptians shall worship with the Assyrians.

In that day shall Israel be the third with Egypt and with Assyria, a blessing in the midst of the earth: for that the Lord of hosts hath blessed them, saying, Blessed be Egypt my people, and Assyria the work of my hands, and Israel mine inheritance.¹

And it shall be said in that day, Lo, this is our God; we have waited for him, and he will save us: this is the Lord; we have waited for him, we will be glad and rejoice in his salvation.²

In that day shall a man look unto his Maker, and his eyes shall have respect to the Holy One of Israel.³

In that day shall the Lord be one, and his name one.⁴

The God of the whole earth shall he be called.⁵

¹Isa. 19: 18-24.
²Isa. 25: 9.

³Isa. 17: 7.
⁴Zech. 14: 9.

⁵Isa. 54: 5.